out over four distinct time periods from 1949 until now. It starts with an assessment of China's policy in the first half of the Cold War period until 1971, followed by the US–Soviet–China strategic triangle period from 1971 to the end of the Cold War. Third is the post–Cold War period from 1989 to 2009, and the fourth and final period covers developments in the last decade after the global financial crisis and the forming of a "new era" in China's grand strategy. Nonetheless, before I analyse the four time periods, it is necessary to further outline the four variables informing China's policy on India and what kind of balancing strategies we could expect China to pursue towards India.

Geopolitics, balance of power, and balancing strategies

China's foreign policy is at any given time shaped and influenced by the balance of power in the international system. In their search for security and survival, great powers tend to balance against the strongest state in the international system.[5] During the early phase of the Cold War, China leaned towards the Soviet Union in order to balance the United States, and then in the second half of the Cold War, it worked with the United States to balance the Soviet Union. In the post–Cold War era of US unipolarity, balancing behaviour was less evident in international affairs[6] but is now gradually regaining its prominence with an emerging US–China bipolar structure.[7] China's alignment and balancing behaviour vis-à-vis the two superpowers, the Soviet Union and the United States, has had a significant impact on its policy towards India.

Even if India has not been a pole in the world structure during these periods, as a major power bordering China,